

A young woman with long brown hair is standing on a wooden deck in front of a cabin. She is wearing a red and black plaid shirt that is open at the waist and white denim shorts. She is smiling and pointing towards the camera with her right hand. The background shows a wooden cabin with large windows and a forest of tall trees.

That Week in the Woods

I watched my
girlfriend with
her "just a friend"



Evan Slate

THAT WEEK IN THE WOODS

I watched my girlfriend with her "just
friends" man

Evan Slate

PMI

Copyright © PMI Evan Slate

All rights reserved

The characters and events portrayed in this book are fictitious. Any similarity to real persons, living or dead, is coincidental and not intended by the author.

No part of this book may be reproduced, or stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without express written permission of the publisher.

I turned off the highway onto the forest road and the asphalt gave way to gravel under the tires. Jess leaned forward from the back seat, her arms draped over the headrest between me and Roman, her face appearing in the gap.

"This is where it starts getting good," she said. "Wait till you see how thick the trees get."

Roman looked out the passenger window at the forest rising on both sides. "It's already pretty dense."

"This is nothing," Jess said. She was beaming with excitement. She was close enough that I could smell her scent. "Owen, tell him about the elk we saw last time."

"Three of them," I said. "Just standing in the road about a mile from here."

"They didn't even move," Jess added. "We sat there for like ten minutes just watching them." Her eyes went big and round at the side of Roman's head.

Her hand rested on Roman's shoulder now, fingers curled over the fabric of his t-shirt. She was wearing denim cutoffs frayed white at the edges and a thin strappy top, pale blue and nearly see-through in the sunlight, the outline of her bra visible underneath. Her hair was dark and loose, falling forward into his lap as she leaned between the seats.

The road narrowed and the trees closed in, pine and Douglas fir blocking out the sky. Gravel popped under the tires and dust rose in the rearview mirror, hanging in the still, hot air behind us.

"How'd you even find this place?" Roman asked.

"Owen's cousin used to bring his family up here," Jess said. "He told us about it last summer. We came up twice last year, just him and me."

"It's pretty remote," I said. "No cell service once you're past the ridge."

"Perfect," Roman said.

Jess laughed. "That's what I said. You've been in the city what, three weeks? You haven't even seen what it's actually like out here."

"That's was her whole reason for inviting you," I added, glancing at him. "She was worried you'd think the whole place was just downtown and industrial parks."

"I wasn't worried," Jess said, squeezing Roman's shoulder. "I just wanted to show you the best parts of living around here."

We hit the first cattle guard and the car rattled over the metal grate. The road curved upward, following the grade of the hill, and through the trees on the right I caught first silver flashes of running water, the river flowing low and clear over pale grey stones.

"Is that it?" Roman asked, pointing toward the water.

"That's it," Jess said. "We can get down to it from the cabin. There's this spot just downstream that's perfect for swimming."

The second cattle guard appeared and I slowed, looking for the turnoff. A wooden post on the left had a number burned into it, barely visible under peeling paint. The track beyond it was narrow, two tire ruts separated by a strip of wild grass and weeds.

I turned onto it and the branches immediately closed in overhead, scraping the roof of the car. Jess sat back in her seat but kept her hand on Roman's shoulder.

"This part always makes me nervous," she said. "Like we're going to stall and die out here, nobody would find us." She seemed excited at the prospect.

"We're fine," I said.

The track curved through the trees and then opened into a clearing. The cabin stood at the far end, a tall classic A-frame with dark-stained wood and glass all down the front, the roof rising steeply to a peak. A narrow porch wrapped around the visible side and the windows reflected the trees and sky in fractured panels.

"Wow," Roman said.

Jess leaned forward again, grinning. "Right?"

I pulled up close to the porch and cut the engine. The sudden silence felt heavy, just the ticking of the cooling motor and the constant low rush of the river somewhere behind the cabin.

Jess pushed open her door and climbed out, stretching her arms overhead. Her top rode up, showing a strip of pale skin above the waistband

of her shorts. She walked toward the cabin, head tilted back to look at the peak of the roof.

Roman got out and stood with his hands on his hips, taking it in. He was tall and lean, wearing a faded gray t-shirt and jeans that hung low on his hips, dark hair curling over his collar.

I climbed out and went around to the hatch. The air here was noticeably cooler, shaded by the trees, and I could hear the river clearly now, a steady rush layered under the silence.

"The key's supposed to be in a lockbox on the porch," I called.

Jess was already climbing the steps. She found the lockbox mounted next to the door and I called out the code from my phone. She punched it in and pulled out a single key on a wooden tag.

"Got it," she said, and unlocked the door.

Roman and I grabbed bags from the trunk. He took his duffel and one of the coolers, I took the rest, and we followed Jess inside.

The interior opened up dramatically. The ceiling soared overhead, all exposed beams and angles, and the entire front wall was windows looking out at the trees. A kitchen ran along the left side, simple and clean with open shelves and a butcher block counter. A wood stove stood in the center of the space with a couch and two chairs arranged around it. A narrow hallway led toward the back and in the corner a wooden ladder climbed up to a loft tucked under the peak of the A-frame.

Jess was already at the windows, looking out. "You can see the river from here if you look through the trees."

I set the bags down and walked over. She was right. Through a gap in the pines the water was visible, fast and white over rocks, catching the late sun.

Roman came up beside us, the cooler still in his hand. "This is incredible."

"I told you," Jess said. She turned to him, her eyes bright and green with that dark liner she wore making them look even bigger. Her lips had a faint shine to them, a gloss, and her cheeks were flushed from the warmth of the car. "Way better than the city, right?"

"Way better," he agreed.

She grabbed his arm and pulled him toward the back. "Come see the porch. It's right over the river."

They disappeared down the hallway and I heard the back door open, their voices carrying in from outside. I started unpacking the cooler into the small fridge, pulling out beers and the food we'd brought for the first night.

When they came back Jess was talking about the swimming spot downstream, how the water was deep enough to swim but still clear enough to see the bottom. Roman listened, nodding, still smiling at something she must have said privately to him out back.

"Where am I sleeping?" he asked, looking around.

Jess pointed at the ladder. "Loft. Owen and I get the bedroom. Obviously!"

Roman walked over and looked up. The loft was completely open to the space below, just a platform with a mattress visible and a low railing along the edge. No walls, no privacy.

"That works," he said with a smirk.

He climbed up to check it out and Jess came over to the kitchen. I handed her a beer and she twisted the cap off, took a long drink, then leaned back against the counter.

"This is exactly what we needed," she said.

Roman's footsteps creaked overhead and then he appeared at the railing looking down. "Bed's actually pretty comfortable."

"Good," Jess called up. "Because you're stuck with it all by your lonesome." She snickered to herself looking back up at him.

He grinned and came back down. Jess handed him a beer from the fridge and we stood in the open space drinking the three of us, while the light outside shifted from gold to amber.

"We should bring the rest of the stuff in," I said.

We made another trip to the car, hauling in the second cooler, a box of dry goods, extra blankets. Jess took her bag into the bedroom and I followed with mine. The room was small and plain, just a bed and a narrow dresser, one window facing the trees.

When I came back out Roman had opened the back door again and was standing on the porch. Jess joined him but I stayed just inside the doorway. She leaned over the railing next to him, close, her bare shoulder brushing his arm. The sound of the river was louder out here, filling the space between the trees.

"I think we're going to have a really good week," she said.

Roman lifted his beer toward the trees. "I can tell already." They checked each other with shoulders then she rolled her eyes at him and shook her head.

I brought our bags into the bedroom while Jess unpacked her things from her duffel. She pulled out shorts and shirts and a toiletry bag, laying everything on the dresser. The room was warm from the afternoon sun still caught in the woods.

"I'm going to change," she said. "It's too hot for jeans."

I nodded and went back out to the main room. Roman was up in the loft, arranging his stuff on the floor beside the mattress. I could see him through the railing, moving around in the small space.

Jess came out a few minutes later in loose cotton shorts, pale gray and worn soft, and a white tank top. No bra underneath, the fabric thin enough that I could see the shape of her clearly. Her hair was pulled up now in a messy knot at the back of her head, a few strands falling loose around her face.

"Much better," she said, padding barefoot across the wood floor to the kitchen. "What should we make?"

I opened the box of food we'd brought. "Pasta? We've got sauce and garlic bread."

"Perfect," she said.

Roman came down the ladder and joined us in the kitchen. The space was small, barely room for two people to work, but somehow all three of us ended up there. Jess filled a pot with water and set it on the stove. I pulled out the sauce and the bread. Roman found a cutting board and started slicing tomatoes we'd brought for a salad.

Jess reached across Roman for the olive oil on the shelf above the counter. She pressed her whole side against him, stretching up on her toes. His hands came to her hips automatically, steadying her.

"Got it," she said, settling back down but not moving away immediately.

He kept his hands on her another second before letting go. She turned and smiled at him, then moved to the stove to drizzle oil into the heating pot.

The water boiled and Jess dumped in the pasta. Steam rose and fogged the window above the sink. Roman moved to stand beside her, both of them looking out at the trees going dark.

"You can't see anything," she said.

"Here," Roman said. He stepped behind her and reached around to unlatch the window, pushing it open. The evening air came in, cooler now, and Jess leaned back into him again, looking out at the clearing and the trees beyond.

"That's nice," she said.

His hands were on her hips again, thumbs resting on the bare skin where her tank top had ridden up. She didn't move and neither did he for a moment, both of them just standing there looking out the open window.

I set the table with mismatched plates I found in the cabinet. Forks and knives. Three glasses for water.

Jess stirred the pasta and Roman stepped back to finish the salad. We worked around each other, Jess brushing past me to get the colander, Roman reaching over my shoulder for the pepper grinder. The kitchen smelled like garlic and tomato and the smell of the propane burner.

We ate at the small table by the front windows, the food plain but good. Jess sat between us, her legs pulled up under her in the chair. She was animated, talking about the hike we should do tomorrow, the swimming spot downstream, whether we should try to find the trail that supposedly went up to an overlook on the ridge.

"We should definitely swim," Roman said.

"The water's freezing though," I said.

"That's the good part," Jess said. She reached across and stole a piece of bread off Roman's plate. He raised an eyebrow at her and she grinned, taking a bite as though challenging him.

After dinner we cleaned up together. Jess washed, I dried, Roman put things away in the cabinets. The light outside was almost gone, just a deep blue glow through the trees.

"Let's sit outside," Jess said. "We should start the fire."

I grabbed a bottle of wine from the counter and Roman found the corkscrew. Jess took the glasses and we went out the back door onto the porch. Just took Roman by the hand as though he needed help finding his way. A stone fire pit sat in a clearing twenty feet from the cabin, surrounded by split log benches. I could hear the river beyond the trees, louder in the darkness.

Roman and I got the fire going with kindling and newspaper from a box beside the pit. The flames caught quickly and spread through the dry wood. Jess sat on the logs watching, her knees pulled up to her chest.

When the fire got going we joined her. Roman sat on beside and Jess shifted to sit closer to him, leaning back between his knees. She stretched her legs out and put her bare feet in his lap.

"My feet are killing me," she said. "Those shoes I wore in the car were a mistake."

Roman's hands came to her feet without hesitation, thumbs pressing into her arches. She made a small sound and let her head fall back against his knee, eyes closing.

"That feels so amazing," she said.

I sat in one of the Adirondack chairs pulled up near the fire, pouring wine into the three glasses. I handed them out and we drank, watching the fire catch and grow. The smoke rose straight up in the still air, sharp and sweet.

Jess's face was relaxed, eyes still closed, Roman's hands working over her feet and ankles. His fingers pressed into the tension at her heel, then slid up to her calf. She sighed and shifted, settling more fully against his leg.

"You're so good at that," she said.

"Years of practice," he said.

"On who?"

He laughed. "I'm always the designated massage person."

"Lucky girlfriends," she murmured.

The fire popped and sent sparks up into the darkness. The woods around us were completely black now, the only light coming from the flames and the faint glow of the cabin windows behind us. I could hear night sounds starting up, crickets and the rustle of something moving through the undergrowth.

Jess opened her eyes and looked at the fire, her feet still in Roman's lap. His hands had gone still but stayed put, resting warm on her skin.

"This is so perfect," she said. "I'm so glad we did this."

"Me too," Roman said.

We sat in silence for a while, drinking wine, watching the fire burn and feeding it more wood to keep it going. The wine made everything feel softer, the edges of the darkness less sharp.

Jess shifted and pulled her feet back, turning to sit sideways on the step facing Roman. She tucked her legs up and wrapped her arms around her knees.

"Tell Owen about that time you got stuck in Portland during that ice storm," she said.

Roman laughed. "Oh god, that was a nightmare."

"I'm not an outdoorsy type, first of all," he started. He told the story and Jess laughed in all the funny spots, even though she'd clearly heard it before. Her hand reached out at one point and squeezed his knee, casual and easy. When he finished she was grinning.

"You should tell him about the wedding," Roman said to her.

"Which wedding?"

"Your cousin's."

"Oh no," she said, but she was already laughing so hard she was bending over.

She told a story about a reception that turned into chaos, something about a broken cake stand and a runaway dog. I laughed along even though I'd heard this one before too. They had a rhythm together, the two of them, a way of talking that built momentum. They were just friends, she kept saying.

The fire burned lower and the cold started creeping in. Jess wrapped her arms around herself and shivered.

"We should probably go in," I said.

"Yeah," she said, but she didn't move yet.

Roman stood first and offered her his hand. She took it and he pulled her up. We carried the glasses inside and I put out the fire, spreading the coals so they'd cool.

Inside the cabin was warm from the heat of cooking. Jess went to the bedroom and came back with a sweatshirt pulled on over her tank top. Roman climbed the ladder to the loft and I heard him moving around up there, the creak of the bed frame as he tested it.

Jess stood at the base of the ladder looking up. "You going to be good up there?"

"Yeah," he called down. "Surprisingly comfortable."

She smiled and turned to me. "I'm exhausted."

"Me too."

We went into the bedroom and closed the door. Through the ceiling I could hear Roman still moving around in the loft, settling in. Jess changed into sleep shorts and got into bed. I changed and climbed in beside her.

She curled against me, her head on my chest, and was asleep almost immediately. I lay awake for a while longer, listening to the cabin settle and the river running constant outside.

I woke to voices outside and light coming hard through the bedroom window. Jess's side of the bed was empty, the sheets thrown back. I got up and pulled on shorts and a t-shirt.

When I came out Jess and Roman were already on the back porch, sitting on the steps with mugs of coffee. Jess was still in her sleep shorts and an oversized t-shirt that hung off one shoulder, her legs bare and pale in the morning sun. Her hair was a mess, dark tangles falling around her face.

"Morning," she called when she saw me through the screen door.

I poured coffee from the pot on the stove and joined them outside. The air was cool still, the sun not yet high enough to burn off the chill. The river sounded louder in the morning, cutting through the quiet.

"How'd you sleep?" I asked Roman.

"Great actually," he said. "Better than my apartment."

Jess laughed. "That's not saying much. Your apartment is terrible."

"It's not terrible."

"It's a box with no windows."

"It has a window."

"That looks at a brick wall," she said up to me. She nudged his leg with her bare foot. "Admit it, it's terrible."

He grinned. "Fine. It's terrible."

We sat drinking coffee and watching the light move through the trees. Birds called from somewhere upstream, sharp and insistent.

"We should hike up to that overlook," Jess said. "Before it gets too hot."

"How far is it?" Roman asked.

"Maybe an hour? Owen and I did it last time."

I nodded. "It's not bad. Steep in a couple places but worth it."

We finished coffee and went inside. Jess disappeared into the bedroom and came out ten minutes later in black athletic shorts that sat low on her hips and a gray sports bra, nothing else. Her hair was pulled back in a ponytail and her face was bare except for the faint shine of sunscreen on her nose and cheeks.

"Ready?" she said.

We filled water bottles and I grabbed a small pack with snacks. Roman changed into hiking shoes and we headed out the back, following a narrow

trail that started at the edge of the clearing and climbed up into the forest.

Jess walked between us at first, stepping over roots and ducking under low branches. The trail was overgrown in places, ferns crowding in from both sides. Within ten minutes we were all breathing harder, the grade steep and relentless.

Jess moved ahead, then fell back, then drifted to Roman's side. She bumped her hip into his as they navigated around a boulder.

"Watch out," she said, grinning.

"I'm watching," he said, and bumped her back.

She laughed and pushed him. He grabbed her arm to steady himself, exaggerating the stumble, and she squealed and shoved him harder. They were both laughing. "my boyfriend's gonna get you for that, " she said.

The trail leveled briefly and then rose again. A fallen log blocked the path, too high to step over easily. I climbed over first and turned back. Roman went next, then reached back for Jess.

She took his hand and tried to swing her leg over but the log was slick with moss. Roman grabbed her waist with both hands and lifted her, setting her down on the other side. His hands stayed on her waist a moment longer and she stood close to him, looking up at him, not stepping back.

"Thank you for that, such a gentleman," she said.

"No problem my lady."

We kept climbing. The trees thinned as we got higher and the air felt drier. Jess was telling a story about a hiking trip she and Roman had done years ago, before she'd met me. She was animated, using her hands, and Roman laughed at what she said.

The trail opened into a clearing at the top of a ridge. The view spread out below us, the forest rolling away in every direction, the river a silver thread cutting through the valley. The cabin was invisible under the canopy.

Jess walked to the edge and stood looking out, hands on her hips. Her skin was flushed from the climb, a sheen of sweat on her shoulders and the exposed strip of her stomach where the sports bra ended.

"This is incredible," Roman said, coming to stand beside her.

"I know," she said. "It's even better in fall."

We sat on the flat rocks at the edge and passed around the water bottles. The sun was higher now, hot on our faces. Jess lay back on the rock, arms spread, eyes closed.

"I could stay up here all day," she said.

"We'd cook for you," I said.

"Worth it."

We rested for twenty minutes and then started back down. The descent was faster, almost too fast, all of us slipping on loose dirt and grabbing trees to slow down. Jess shrieked when she slid into Roman and he caught her around the waist, both of them laughing.

By the time we reached the cabin we were all sweating and thirsty. Jess went straight to the outdoor shower stall beside the cabin and turned it on, standing under the spray fully clothed, tipping her head back.

"Oh my god that's cold," she screamed, but she didn't move.

Roman and I went inside and I started making lunch while he cleaned up in the bathroom. Jess came in dripping, her sports bra and shorts soaked dark, water running down her legs onto the floor.

"I'm getting the porch daybed," she announced, and grabbed a towel from the bedroom.

By the time I brought sandwiches out to the back porch she was stretched out on the daybed in a different bikini top, black with thin straps, and dry shorts. Her hair was wet and combed back from her face. A book lay open on her stomach.

We ate on the porch and then I went back inside to clean up. Through the window I could see them on the daybed together now. Roman had joined her, sitting at the far end with her legs stretched across his lap. She was still holding the book but not reading, talking instead, gesturing with one hand.

She poked his side with her toe. He grabbed her ankle and she squealed, trying to pull away, but he held her. She was laughing, squirming, trying to kick free with her other foot. He caught that ankle too and held both, grinning at her.

"Stop," she said, still laughing.

"Stop poking me then."

"I barely touched you."

"You poked me hard."

She wriggled her feet and he let go. She immediately poked him again with her toe and he lunged for her ankle. She shrieked with laughter and tried to pull away but he was faster, grabbing her foot and running his fingers up the sole. She jerked and twisted, laughing so hard she couldn't speak.

"Roman stop, oh my god! Owen save me!"

He let go and she lay there breathing hard, grinning at him. Her book had fallen onto the floor. She propped herself up on her elbows and pushed her wet hair back from her face.

I finished the dishes and dried my hands. When I looked out again she was lying with her head on his thigh, legs bent, feet tucked up. He had one hand resting on her shoulder, the other holding his phone. She'd picked up her book again but didn't seem to be reading it.

I went out and sat in one of the chairs. Jess glanced over and smiled at me.

"You should read out here," she said. "It's perfect."

"I might."

"I'm not going to move for hours," she said. "This is the most comfortable spot in the world."

Roman's hand moved absently from her shoulder to her hair, fingers combing through the drying strands. She shifted, settling more comfortably against his leg.

The afternoon stretched out quiet and warm. Jess did eventually read, or at least turn pages. Roman scrolled through his phone reading too. I sat watching the light move through the trees and listening to the river.

Later Jess got up and went inside for water. She came back with bottles for all of us but instead of returning to the daybed she sat on the porch railing, one leg bent and foot braced against the wood.

"We should go down to the swimming spot tomorrow," she said.

"How cold is it really?" Roman asked.

"Freezing," I said.

"Refreshing," Jess corrected. She tipped her water bottle at me. "Don't scare him off."

"I'm not scared," Roman said.

"Good." She hopped down from the railing and stretched, arms overhead, her back arching. The movement lifted her bikini top and showed the pale skin of her stomach, the waistband of her shorts riding low.

She caught Roman looking and grinned at him. "What?"

"Nothing," he said.

"Liar." She went over and poked him in the shoulder. He grabbed her wrist and she twisted away, laughing. "he only wish."

The sun dropped lower and the air started to cool. Jess sat with her feet tucked under her, talking about what else we should do this week, whether we should try to find the other trail she'd heard about, whether we had enough food or if someone needed to drive back to town.

We took wine out to the fire pit. Roman got the fire going this time and Jess sat on the logs. She stretched her legs out he was already sitting and her feet landed in his lap naturally, like they'd agreed on it beforehand.

The sun dropped behind the ridge and the temperature fell with it. I went to get more firewood at the road and came back to find Jess in the kitchen wearing her black bikini top and shorts from the afternoon, her hair mostly dry now and falling loose around her shoulders.

"I'm making stir fry," I said, pulling vegetables from the cooler.

"I can help," she said.

Roman came in from the porch and the three of us gathered in the small kitchen again. I started chopping peppers and onions while Jess got a pan heating on the stove. Roman leaned against the counter watching, drinking a beer.

Jess reached up to the shelf above the stove for the soy sauce but couldn't quite get it. She pressed her whole body back against Roman, using him for balance as she stretched on her toes. One of her legs bent, foot braced against her opposite knee in a flamingo pose, her bare back against his chest. He seemed purposefully off-balance.

"Almost," she said, fingers brushing the bottle.

His hands came to her hips, steadying her. She grabbed the bottle and came back down but didn't step away. She turned her head to look at him over her shoulder, grinning.

"Got it," she said privately with a smirk.

She stayed pressed against him another second before moving to the stove. Roman's hands dropped away but only slowly.

I dumped the vegetables into the hot pan and they sizzled. Jess poured in soy sauce and some oil, stirring everything together. The kitchen filled with the smell of garlic and ginger.

When the food was ready I served it on plates and Jess picked up a piece of broccoli from the pan with her fingers, blowing on it to cool it.

"Roman, try this," she said.

She held it up to his mouth and he leaned forward and took it, her fingers brushing his lips. He chewed and nodded.

"Good," he said.

"Right?" She picked up another piece and ate it herself, licking her fingers. Her tongue caught the sauce on her thumb and she made a small sound of satisfaction.

We carried the plates to the table but Jess stayed in the kitchen, picking at the food left in the pan. Roman came back for water and she fed him another piece of pepper, laughing when he tried to catch her wrist.

I sat at the table and watched them Play. She was still holding a piece of food and he was leaning down, mouth open, and she teased him before she popped it in. When he straightened up she was smiling at him. He leaned in and kissed her then. It looked almost natural. It was just a quick press of his mouth to hers, and over in a second.

She blinked and her smile shifted to something softer. Then she turned and brought the pan to the table. I chalked it up as an accident, a momentary lapse between friends who are already pretty physical with each other.

We ate and talked about the hike, about the view from the ridge, about whether the trail kept going or if that was the end. Jess was animated, gesturing with her fork, her eyes bright in the lamplight.

After dinner she disappeared into the bedroom and came back in a loose cotton dress, faded blue and worn soft, hanging off her shoulders. It moved when she walked in a way that made it clear she wasn't wearing anything underneath.

We took wine and glasses out to the fire pit. I got the fire started and Roman arranged the log benches while Jess sat on the porch steps watching. Once the flames caught we settled into the chairs around the fire.

Jess sat in one chair, I took another, Roman a third. We drank and watched the fire grow. The darkness pressed in around us and the stars came out overhead, more than you'd ever seen in the city.

"I think I need a refill," Jess said, holding up her empty glass. She stood and headed toward the cabin.

Roman got up too. "I'll come too."

They went inside together and I sat alone by the fire. Minutes passed. Five, then ten. I fed another log into the flames and listened to the river and the night sounds in the woods.

When they came back out, Jess's hair was messed, pieces falling out of the loose knot she'd twisted it into. Her face was flushed and she was

laughing at something Roman had said. They both carried full glasses of wine.

Instead of sitting in her own chair Jess perched on the arm of Roman's, one leg bent and foot braced on the seat between his thighs. Her hand came to rest on the back of his neck, fingers playing with his hair.

"What were you talking about in there?" I asked.

"Nothing," Jess said. "Just an old road trip."

She took a sip of wine and her fingers now moved in Roman's hair, absent and easy. He shifted in the chair and her hand went still for a moment, then continued.

We sat and drank and talked about nothing, plans for tomorrow, whether the weather would hold, if we'd heard the forecast before we lost cell service. Jess's hand never left Roman's neck.

After a while she shifted and slid down from the arm of the chair into his lap, curling sideways against him, her legs draped over the arm. He adjusted to make room for her and his arm came around her waist naturally, holding her in place.

She rested her head against his shoulder and closed her eyes. "This is so nice," she murmured.

I got up and stoked the fire, pushing the logs closer together. Sparks rose and disappeared into the darkness. When I sat back down Jess's eyes were still closed and Roman's hand was resting on her bare thigh where the dress had ridden up.

We stayed out until the fire burned low and the cold became uncomfortable. Jess unfolded herself from Roman's lap and stood, stretching. The dress fell back into place and she wrapped her arms around herself.

"I'm freezing," she said. "Let's go in."

We carried the glasses inside and I spread out the coals to let the fire die. When I came in Jess was in the bedroom and Roman was climbing the ladder to the loft.

I went into the bedroom and closed the door. Jess was already in bed, the covers pulled up. I changed and slid in beside her.

She rolled toward me immediately, her hand coming to my chest. "Hey," she said.

"Hey."

She kissed me, her mouth tasting like wine. Her hand slid down my stomach and lower, wrapping around me. I was already half hard and her touch made me harden fully.

"I want you right fucking now," she said against my mouth, and she grinned.

She pushed me onto my back and straddled me, pulling her t-shirt over her head and dropping it on the floor. Her breasts were small and pale in the dim light coming through the window. She reached down and guided me inside her.

She was wet already, sliding down onto me with a small gasp. Her hands braced on my chest and she started moving, rocking her hips slowly at first and then faster. Her breathing got heavier and she leaned forward, hair falling around her face.

"God," she said. "Yes." She said it too loud I thought, given how quiet the cabin was and with our guest upstairs above us.

She'd always been quiet during sex, restrained, but now she was making sounds I'd never heard from her, little gasps and moans, words I couldn't quite make out. Her hips moved harder, grinding down on me.

I grabbed her hips and she arched her back, head tipping back. Her hands came up to her breasts, touching herself, pinching and twisting her nipples. She'd never done that before.

"Don't stop," she said, louder than I'd ever heard her go.

She ground down harder on me, chasing it, her whole body growing tense. I could feel her tightening around me and then she was coming, her mouth falling open, a sharp cry escaping that she didn't even try to muffle.

She kept moving through it, drawing it out, and the sight and sound of her pushed me over. I came hard, gripping her hips, pulling her down onto me.

She collapsed forward onto my chest, breathing hard, her skin damp with sweat. We lay like that for a long moment, her heart hammering against mine.

Eventually she rolled off and curled into my side. Her hand traced patterns on my chest, lazy and satisfied.

"That was amazing," she said softly.

"Yeah," I said.

She was asleep within minutes, her breathing evening out. I lay awake longer, staring at the ceiling, listening to the sounds of the cabin settling

around us. From somewhere above I thought I heard movement, the creak of the loft frame, but it could have been anything.

I woke to an empty bed and voices outside. The bedroom was bright with morning sun and the sheets on Jess's side were cool. I got up and pulled on shorts and a t-shirt, moving quietly through the cabin.

Through the screen door I could see them on the back porch steps. Jess was sitting one step below Roman, settled between his knees, leaning back against his body. She was wearing just a white tank top and light blue hipster panties, her legs bare and stretched out in front of her. Roman's chin rested on her head and his arms were loosely around her body.

They were talking quietly, voices low enough that I couldn't make out the words. Jess's hair was messy from sleep, falling around her shoulders, and she had one holding, wrapped around Roman's forearm.

I went to the kitchen and started coffee, the sound of it filling the quiet cabin. Through the window I watched them. Jess turned her head to say something and her face was close to Roman's, their cheeks nearly touching.

When the coffee was ready I poured three mugs and went out to join them. Jess looked up when the screen door opened and smiled.

"Morning sleepyhead," she said.

"Morning."

I handed them each a mug and sat in one of the chairs. Jess stayed where she was, nestled between Roman's legs, her tank top thin enough that I could see she wasn't wearing a bra. The outline of her was clear against the white fabric.

"Sleep okay?" Roman asked.

"Yeah. You?"

"Great."

We drank coffee and watched the light move through the trees. Birds called from the river and the air was cool and clean. Jess shifted, settling more comfortably back against Roman's chest, and he adjusted his arms around her more tightly.

"We should take the canoe out," she said. "I saw it under the cabin yesterday."

"There's only one?" Roman asked.

"Yeah. Only fits two."

I looked at them. "You two should go. I'll hang here."

"You sure?" Jess asked, but she sounded pleased.

"Yeah, I'll read or something."

She twisted to look up at Roman. "Want to?"

"Absolutely."

They finished their coffee and went inside. Jess pulled on shorts over her underwear but kept the tank top. Roman changed into swim trunks. I helped them drag the canoe out from under the cabin and carry it down to the river.

The water was clear and fast, running shallow over smooth stones. Jess stepped in carefully, the cold making her gasp. Roman steadied the canoe while she climbed in, then pushed off and jumped in behind her.

"We'll be back in a bit," Jess called.

I watched them paddle downstream, Jess in the front, Roman in the back steering. They rounded a bend and disappeared into the trees. The sound of their paddles faded and then it was just the river and the forest.

I went back to the cabin and refilled my coffee. The porch was warm now, full sun, and I settled into one of the chairs with a book I'd brought. The pages turned slowly. I read the same paragraph three times without absorbing it.

The forest sounds closed in around me. Birds and insects, the constant rush of the river, wind moving through the high branches. Occasionally I heard distant laughter from downstream, Jess's voice carrying over the water, bright and sharp.

An hour passed, then another. I went inside and made a sandwich, ate it standing at the counter. Through the back window I could see the empty river, the canoe nowhere visible.

When they finally appeared it was sudden, the canoe shooting around the upstream bend, both of them paddling hard and laughing. They were soaked, water streaming off them. Jess's tank top clung to her body completely transparent, her breasts and the darkness of her nipples clearly visible through the wet fabric.

They beached the canoe and climbed out. Jess was breathless, grinning, pushing wet hair back from her face.

"That was insane," she said. "We hit rapids."

"You call those rapids?" Roman said.

"As if!"

They were both dripping, leaving dark footprints on the wood as they came up onto the porch. Jess's tank top was plastered to her skin but she

didn't seem to notice or care. Water ran down her legs and pooled around her feet.

"I need to change," she said, and went inside.

Roman grabbed a towel from the railing and dried his face and arms. I followed them in and found Jess in the bedroom with the door half open. She was peeling off the wet tank top, pulling it over her head. Her back was to the door, bare and pale.

Roman walked past in the hallway and his eyes flicked toward the open door. I saw him look, saw him pause for just a fraction of a second, then keep walking to the bathroom with a smirk to himself.

Jess stepped out of her wet shorts and underwear and stood naked for a moment, reaching for dry clothes on the bed. She pulled on a different bikini, this one red with string ties, and a pair of cutoff shorts.

When she came out her hair was still wet, combed back from her face. Roman was on the couch and she went straight to him, climbing into his lap facing him, her legs on either side of his hips.

"You're still wet," he said in a bagging way.

"So are you."

She gasped as though scandalized, and she glanced over her shoulder before she poked him in the ribs. He jerked, laughing. His hands came to her waist automatically.

"Don't start," he said.

"Start what?" She poked him again and he grabbed her wrists. She squealed and tried to pull away but he held on. She twisted and he let go of one wrist to tickle her side. She shrieked and fell sideways off his lap onto the couch, laughing so hard she couldn't breathe.

"Stop, oh my god!"

He didn't stop. His fingers found her ribs and she writhed, kicking her legs, trying to get away. She managed to get her hands free and went for his sides but he was faster, catching her wrists again and pinning them.

They were both breathless, faces flushed, grinning at each other. She was half under him on the couch, her legs tangled with his.

"Truce," she gasped.

"Say you surrender."

"Never."

He tickled her again and she shrieked, thrashing. "Okay okay, I surrender!"

He let go and she lay there catching her breath, her chest heaving. He stayed leaning over her a moment, both of them looking at each other, and then he sat back and she pushed herself upright, shoving at his shoulder.

"You're truly evil," she said, but she was still grinning.

She curled into his side, tucking her legs up. His arm came around her shoulders and they stayed like that, both of them settling into the quiet.

We went to the porch. Jess talked about the river, the spots they'd found, a beaver dam they'd seen. Her eyes were bright and her hands moved as she described it.

The afternoon drifted. Jess showered and came out in a short sundress, yellow and faded, the hem hitting high on her thighs where she left it on buttoned high up. We started dinner together, all three of us in the kitchen again. She was making a sauce and kept tasting it, adjusting. Roman was beside her and she lifted the spoon to his mouth.

"Try it."

He tasted it and nodded. "Good. Maybe more salt?"

She added salt and stirred, then tasted again herself, the spoon going into her mouth. When she pulled it out her tongue caught a drop on her lip and she licked it away slowly.

She offered the spoon to Roman again and this time when he leaned in she held it closer, making him come to her. His lips closed around the spoon and she watched his face.

"Better?" she asked.

"Perfect."

She turned back to the stove and he stayed close, watching her work. A drop of sauce landed on her chin but she didn't notice. Roman reached out and wiped it away with his thumb.

She turned to look at him when his thumb was still there, resting against her lower lip. She smiled and parted her lips, and her tongue flicking out to taste his thumb. He pulled his hand back but only slowly.

"You had sauce," he said.

"Uh-huh."

She turned back to the stove but she was grinning. I put out things on the table, and pretended I hadn't seen any of it.

We ate dinner and cleaned up. The sun dropped behind the trees and the light turned gold and soft. Jess stood at the sink washing dishes and Roman came up beside her to dry.

Later we took wine out to the fire. The routine was set now, familiar and easy. Jess sat on a chair and Roman sat beside her and her feet found his lap without either of them saying anything.

Later inside, we pulled the couch closer to the small table and Roman set up his laptop. He'd downloaded a few movies before we left the city and we scrolled through the options. Jess picked something, I couldn't even tell you what it was, and we settled in to watch.

Jess sat in the middle, me on one side, Roman on the other. The opening credits rolled and she pulled her legs up under her, the yellow sundress spreading across her thighs.

Ten minutes in she shifted, leaning toward Roman. By twenty minutes in, her head was on his shoulder, her hair spilling across his arm. She adjusted again, stretching her legs out across my lap while her upper body stayed back against Roman.

His arm came around her naturally, his hand resting on her side. I put my hands on her shins, the skin smooth and warm under my palms.

The movie played on but I wasn't watching it. I was watching Roman's hand move slowly, almost absently, from her side down to her hip. His fingers found the hem of her dress and slipped underneath, resting on her bare thigh.

Jess shifted, pressing into his touch. Her breathing changed, deepened. His thumb moved in small circles on her skin.

On screen something exploded but I had no idea what the plot was anymore. Jess's legs were warm across my lap and I could see Roman's hand under the fabric of her dress, the movement of his fingers.

She turned her face into his shoulder, her lips near his neck. Her hand came up to rest on his chest, fingers splayed.

The movie ended and the screen went dark. We sat in the sudden silence for a moment before Roman reached forward and closed the laptop.

Jess sat up slowly, stretching. The dress had ridden high on her thighs and she tugged it down as she stood, looking at Roman.

"I'm going to shower," she said. Her voice was soft, a little rough.

"I'll get the fire started," Roman said.

"I'll clean up," I said.

Jess disappeared into the bedroom and I heard the bathroom door close, then the sound of water running. Roman went outside and I carried the wine glasses to the kitchen, rinsing them in the sink.

Through the window I could see him at the fire pit, crouching to arrange kindling. The muscles in his back moved under his t-shirt as he worked. Smoke began to rise and then flames caught.

I dried the glasses and put them away. The shower was still running. I stood at the counter, not really doing anything, other than thinking.

When Jess came out she was in sleep shorts and a loose white top, the kind that hung off her shoulders. No bra underneath, her nipples visible as shadows through the thin fabric. Her hair was wet and combed back, face bare and clean.

"Ready?" she asked.

We went out to the fire together. Roman had it burning well now, flames rising into the darkness. He'd pulled the blankets from the storage box and draped one across his lap.

Jess went straight to him, not even pausing at the other chairs. She climbed into his lap sideways, curling against him, and he lifted the blanket to cover them both. His hands disappeared under it, resting on her bare thighs.

I sat in one of the chairs and poured wine for all of us. The fire popped and sparked and the smoke rose straight up into the still air. The forest was dark around us, just the orange glow of the flames and the stars overhead.

Jess took a sip of wine and set her glass down. She shifted in Roman's lap, turning toward him. Her hand came up to his face, fingers tracing along his jaw.

"You missed a spot shaving," she said softly.

"Did I?"

"Right here." Her fingers touched the underside of his jaw and then her lips followed, pressing a kiss there, light, playful.

She kissed his jaw again, then lower on his neck. Her teeth grazed his skin and he made a sound low in his throat and looked at me.

We talked on and off but mostly, we were filled with a drifting sense of quietness.

His hands tightened on her thighs under the blanket. I could see the movement of his arms, his grip shifting higher.

Jess giggled at something against his neck, the sound breathless. She squirmed in his lap and his hands moved to her hips, holding her still.

"Stop moving," he said softly to her, but he was smiling.

"Why should I?" She ground down and his breath caught. She did it again, deliberate this time, and he grabbed her hips harder.

"Jess."

"What?" She was grinning now, her eyes bright in the firelight. "Tell Roman to stop bugging me," she said to me, and she chuckled.

"What are you doing?"

"Nothing," she said

Then she leaned up and kissed the corner of his mouth, but pulled back before he could turn his head to catch her lips.

She settled against his chest, tucking her head under his chin. His arms came around her and they sat like that, the blanket covering both of them. Under it I could see movement, small shifts, his hands on her body somewhere.

"How did you become friends anyway?" I said.

She twisted up, so her face was grazing his jaw. With a grin, she said, "yeah, how did we become friends?"

"Shared house," Roman finally said after a long pause during which they grinned knowingly at each other.

"He took me in when I was a poor waif," she said half rolling out of his lap to find me over her shoulder. They hung onto each other to keep her from falling out altogether and they laughed.

The fire burned and we sat in silence. Jess's breathing had lowered and for a moment I thought she might be falling asleep. But then her hand emerged from under the blanket and reached for her wine glass. She took a drink and offered the glass to Roman. He drank from it, his eyes on her face as she tipped it out his mouth watching carefully.

"We should do this every night," she murmured.

"Yeah," he said.

She shifted again and this time the movement was unmistakable. I could see a slow roll of her hips. Roman's jaw tightened and his arms disappeared further under the blanket. She made a small sound and bit her lip before pulling the blanket up to cover them both up to their necks.

I stood up. "I'm going to get more wood."

Neither of them looked at me. I walked around the back of the cabin where the woodpile was stacked and stood there in the darkness, hands on the rough bark, breathing the cold air.

When I came back with the wood Jess was still in Roman's lap but they were both quiet, still. I fed the fire and sat back down.

We stayed out another hour. The temperature dropped and eventually Jess stood, the blanket falling away. Her shirt was twisted and her shorts had ridden up. She looked flushed, her lips full.

"It's freezing," she said. "We should all go in."

We put the fire down and carried the glasses inside. Roman climbed up to the loft and I heard the bed-frame creak as he settled in.

Jess went into the bedroom and I followed. She was already pulling the sleep shirt over her head, dropping it on the floor. She stood naked for a moment cause they wanting me to look at her before climbing into bed.

I changed and got in beside her. She rolled to face me immediately, her hand sliding down my chest, over my stomach.

"I want you so bad," she said. "I need dick," she whispered in my here and she laughed.

She pushed me onto my back and straddled me. Her hand wrapped around me, guiding me inside her. She was so wet that I slid in all the way on the first thrust she made on me.

"Fuck, Jess," I breathed.

"Be rough with me," she whispered. "Don't be so gentle."

I grabbed her hips and thrust up hard. She gasped, her hands bracing on my chest. I did it again and she moaned, louder than she should have with Roman right above us.

"Yeah," she said. "More like that."

I flipped her onto her back and she wrapped her legs around me, pulling me deeper. Her nails dug into my shoulders, dragging down my back. The pain was sharp and bright.

"Harder," she said.

I fucked her hard, the bed frame hitting the wall with each thrust. She was loud now, making sounds I'd never heard from her, words and gasps and my name.

Her nails dragged down my back again and I felt skin break. She arched under me, her whole body tightening.

"Oh god, oh god, I'm..."

She came with a cry that filled the room, her body shaking under me. I couldn't hold back, the sensation of her clenching around me too much. I came hard, buried deep inside her.

We collapsed together, both breathing hard. She clung to me, her face pressed into my neck.

"That was so good, Mr. your boyfriend,," she murmured.

We lay tangled together as our breathing slowed. Eventually she rolled onto her side and I curled behind her, my arm around her waist.

She was asleep within minutes. I lay awake, my back stinging where her nails had torn my skin.

Above us, through the ceiling, I heard the creak of the loft bed. Movement, shifting weight. Then silence.

I woke to the smell of coffee and something cooking. The bedroom was bright with early sun and Jess's side of the bed was empty again, the sheets thrown back.

I pulled on shorts and went out to the main room. Jess was at the stove in boy-short panties and a stretched-out gray tank top, the neckline hanging loose off one shoulder. No bra, her small breasts moving freely under the thin fabric as she worked. Her hair was a mess, dark tangles falling around her face and down her back.

Roman was at the table, mug in hand, watching her. His eyes followed her movements as she reached up to the high shelf for plates, the tank top riding up to show the pale skin of her lower back, the waistband of her panties.

She was completely unselfconscious, humming something under her breath, moving around the small kitchen like she was alone. She bent to check something in the oven and the boy-shorts pulled tight across her ass.

"Morning," I said.

She turned and smiled. "Hey. I'm making eggs and toast. Coffee's ready."

I poured myself a cup and joined Roman at the table. Jess brought over plates loaded with scrambled eggs and buttered toast. She sat down across from us, pulling one leg up under her, the tank top slipping further off her shoulder.

"I was thinking we could go to that other swimming spot today," she said. "The one further upstream. It's usually warmer."

"How far is it?" Roman asked.

"Maybe forty minutes? It's supposed to be really nice though. Deeper than the spot by the cabin."

We finished breakfast and Jess went to change. She came back in white denim shorts and a white t-shirt, bikini visible underneath, the strings tied at her neck.

We filled water bottles and headed out, following a trail that branched off from the main path behind the cabin. The morning was already warm, the sun cutting through the trees in bright shafts.

Jess and I walked together at first, but the trail narrowed and she moved ahead with Roman. Where the path crossed a rocky section she took his hand for balance, stepping carefully from stone to stone.

When the rocks ended she didn't let go. They walked hand in hand, her fingers laced through his, talking about something I couldn't hear.

The trail climbed and then dropped down toward the sound of rushing water. We emerged at a wide pool, the river spreading out between smooth boulders, the water deep and clear green in the center.

"This is perfect," Jess said.

She pulled her shirt over her head and stepped out of her shorts. The bikini was dark blue, simple triangles tied with strings. She walked to the edge and dipped her toe in.

"It's nice," she said, then jumped in.

She surfaced gasping, hair slicked back, laughing. "Oh my god, it's cold below!"

Roman stripped to his swim trunks and dove in. I followed, the shock of the cold water taking my breath.

Jess swam to the middle where it was deepest. Roman reached her and she shrieked as he dunked her, pushing her head under. She came up sputtering and launched herself at him, trying to push him under in return.

He was stronger and kept his feet. She wrapped her arms around his neck and jumped, trying to use her weight to bring him down. Her legs wrapped around his waist and she clung to him, both of them laughing.

"You have to go under," she said.

"Not happening."

She squeezed tighter, legs locked around him. He spun in the water and she shrieked again, holding on. Finally he let himself sink and they both went under, surfacing seconds later still tangled together.

She didn't let go. They stayed like that, her legs around his waist, his hands supporting her under her thighs. The water lapped between them and they were both breathing hard, faces close.

"Truce?" he said.

"Truce."

She unwrapped her legs slowly and pushed away, floating on her back. I swam in circles, dove under, tried not to watch them.

After a while we got out and spread towels on the warm rocks. Jess lay on her stomach and dug through her bag for sunscreen.

"Roman, do my back?" she asked, holding out the bottle.

He took it and squeezed lotion into his palm. He started at her shoulders, his hands spreading the white cream across her skin in slow, careful strokes. Down her spine, along her sides. His fingers worked the sunscreen in thoroughly, taking his time.

"Don't forget my legs," she said, her voice muffled against her arms.

His hands moved lower, over the backs of her thighs. She shifted, arching into his touch. His palms slid up and down, fingers kneading the muscle. When he reached the edge of her bikini bottom his fingers slipped just barely underneath before sliding away.

"All good," he said.

"Thanks." She turned her head to look at him. "Want me to do yours?"

"Of course." He glanced at me with a smirk.

She sat up and he lay down on his stomach. Her hands moved over his back, efficient and thorough, but I noticed the way her fingers lingered on his shoulders, the way she leaned close to reach his lower back.

We stayed at the pool another hour, swimming and lying in the sun. When we finally packed up to leave, the hike back felt shorter. Jess and Roman walked close together, his arm around her waist. She leaned into him, her head resting on his shoulder as they navigated the trail.

Back at the cabin we were all overheated and grimy. Jess went straight to the outdoor shower stall beside the cabin and turned on the water. She stepped under the spray in her bikini, tipping her head back.

I went inside to get cold water from the fridge. Through the window I could see her in the shower, water streaming over her body. Roman appeared with the towels and stopped at the shower entrance.

"Hand me the soap?" Jess called.

He reached in and grabbed the bar from the shelf, passing it to her. His hand brushed her shoulder and he didn't pull back.

"Do my back?" she asked. "I can't reach."

He stepped into the shower stall with her, still in his swim trunks. She turned her back to him and he soaped his hands, then ran them over her shoulders and down her spine. She bent forward, giving him better access, and his hands worked the soap across her skin.

"Lower," she said.

His hands moved to her lower back, then around to her sides. She giggled when his fingers brushed her ribs.

"Stop trying to tickle me."

"Sorry."

"No you're not."

He kept going, his hands sliding around to her stomach. She leaned back against him, laughing as his hands moved lower, dangerously close to the waistband of her bikini bottom.

"Okay okay, my turn," she said.

She spun around and grabbed the soap, lathering her hands. He turned his back to her and she worked soap across his shoulders. Her hands were small against his back, moving in circles, sliding down to his waist.

When she reached around to his stomach her hands went lower than they'd gone on his back. He sucked in a breath and grabbed her wrists.

"Careful," he said.

"What?" She was grinning. "Just getting you clean." She curled her lips between her teeth with a grin.

She pulled her hands free and rinsed them under the spray. They both stood under the water for another moment, close together, before she stepped out and grabbed a towel.

Roman rinsed off and followed her. I watched from the kitchen window as they walked back to the cabin together, both dripping, her hand on his arm as they talked.

When they came inside Jess went to the bedroom to change. Roman headed for the bathroom. I stood at the counter pretending to sort through the food supplies, my hands busy with nothing in reality.

Jess emerged in a tank top and shorts, her wet hair combed back. She came to the kitchen and stood next to me, close enough that I could smell the soap on her skin.

"That was such a good day," she said.

"Yeah."

She stretched up and kissed my cheek. "What should we do for dinner?"

We discussed options and she started pulling things from the cooler. Roman came out of the bathroom in clean clothes, his hair still damp. He joined us in the kitchen and we fell into the familiar pattern, the three of us moving around the small space, preparing the meal together.

After dinner Jess disappeared into the bedroom and came back wearing a thin slip-style dress, pale pink and worn soft. It hung from thin straps and moved against her body in a way that made it obvious she had nothing on underneath. The fabric was nearly sheer in the lamplight, the shadow of her nipples visible, the curve of her hips, too.

We took wine out to the porch and sat in the chairs watching the light fade. Jess walked to the railing, leaning against it, looking out at the darkening trees.

Roman got up and joined her. She turned and hopped up to sit on the railing, her legs parting as he stepped between them. His hands came to her hips, thumbs pressing into the soft fabric.

"It's so beautiful here, isn't it," she said. She hung her arms around his neck.

"Yeah."

His hands slid up her sides, feeling the shape of her through the dress. She leaned forward, her face close to his, and her hand came up to push into his hair.

And then she kissed him. This one was not quick or playful like before, but slow and deliberate, her mouth opening against his. Her fingers tangled in his hair and his hands tightened on her waist, pulling her closer to the edge of the railing, closer to him.

They stayed like that, kissing deeply, her hand in his hair, his hands all over her body. When she pulled back her lips were thick and her breathing was uneven.

She looked past him to where I sat in the chair. Her eyes were bright, pupils wide.

"Do you want to get more wine?" she asked me.

"Sure."

She slid down from the railing and went inside, the screen door closing behind her. Roman stayed at the railing, his back to me. I could see his shoulders rise and fall with his breathing.

Jess came back with the bottle and refilled all our glasses. Instead of going back to the railing she went to where Roman had sat down and she

faced him, her legs sliding down either side of his hips, and she straddle his lap.

"we haven't seen each other, I mean, really seen each other, in a long time," she said to me as though by way of explanation. "But you're OK, you're cool aren't you?"

"I'm cool," I said. I didn't know what I should say, or what I could say. We'd been alone for days out there far from anywhere. The kissing, the touching, the playing around, the way she dressed, it was hard to remember what was normal and what was not. It all seemed so natural. Everything was happening in such small steps, but I wasn't sure about what was even happening. I mean, if they're just friends, if they had always been just friends, they're just playing around. I didn't want to be that guy, jealous and paranoid and not trusting. Besides, every night just was all over me. I wasn't sure if I wanted for that to change anytime soon.

Her hands came to his shoulders and she leaned in, pressing her mouth to his neck, just below his ear. She looked at me as though checking if that was OK, too. Her lips moved against his skin, kissing, teeth grazing, her eyes not leaving mine. His hands slid up her bare thighs under the dress, gripping her.

She kissed down the side of his neck to his collarbone, her eyes finally pulling away from mine. Then she kissed a trail back up to his jaw. He closed his eyes and leaned his head back as though preparing to just enjoy it. Her hips shifted against him and his breath caught. She did it again, a slow deliberate grind, and his hands tightened on her thighs.

I sat in my chair watching them, the wine glass cold in my hand.

After a while Jess stood up, her dress twisted and riding high on her thighs. She smoothed it down.

"I think I'll get more firewood," she said, glancing at Roman until he understood..

Roman stood. "I'll help."

They walked around the side of the cabin toward the woodpile and disappeared into the darkness. I sat alone listening to the river and the night sounds in the forest.

Minutes passed. Ten, then fifteen. I poured more wine and waited.

When they finally came back Roman was carrying a few pieces of wood, hardly enough for an hour. Jess's hair was messed, pieces falling

loose from the knot she'd twisted it into. Her dress was twisted at the waist and rode high.

They didn't say anything, they just stacked the wood by the door. Jess waited for Roman to sit before sitting back in his lap like nothing happened, curling against his chest. His arms came around her and they stayed like that, quiet.

We finished the wine as the fire burned down. The cold crept in and eventually we went inside.

Roman climbed up to the loft and I heard him moving around above us. Jess went into the bedroom and I followed, closing the door behind us.

Her hand was on me immediately, wrapping around my cock, stroking me. I was already hard.

"Fuck me baby," she said.

She pushed me onto my back and straddled me, sinking down onto me with a gasp. She was soaked, wetter than I'd ever felt her.

She started moving immediately, riding me hard, her hands braced on my chest. Her head fell back and she moaned, loud and shameless.

She ground down harder, chasing pleasure. Her nails dug into my chest and she leaned forward, her hair falling around her face.

"Owen," she gasped. "Oh god, Owen."

She said my name again and again, louder each time, as they wanted someone else to hear her say it. Her whole body was tense, straining. She ground down hard one more time and came with a cry that echoed through the small room, through the whole cabin.

She kept moving, drawing it out, and I couldn't hold back. I grabbed her hips and thrust up into her, coming hard.

She collapsed onto my chest, breathing heavily. We lay tangled together, both slick with sweat.

"I love this," she whispered. "I love how you feel so deep inside me." She said that louder than she needed to as well. "are you sure you're OK about Roman?"

"What about Roman?"

"We're just really friendly together, I guess we're kind of physical together, too. He just gets to me, I can't help it. Is it too much? I mean for you?"

"Well you seem to be enjoying his company an awful lot."

“I think it bothers you. Does he bother you? The way he grabs me? I saw you watching him kiss me.”

“You were kissing him just as much.”

She squealed with embarrassed laughter, buried her face in my neck, and tried to deny it. Then she rolled back onto the pillow. “We're just having fun. There's nothing to worry about. He always leaves just as fast as he comes anyways.”

“Meaning?” I asked.

She gasped with a scandalized grin, and lightly slapped my cheek. “I didn't mean that kind of coming!”

In the morning I got up and pulled on shorts, moving quietly through the cabin, accustomed to her being up before me, to them both being up before me.

The back door was open and I could see them on the porch daybed. Jess was lying with her head in Roman's lap, wearing just white panties and his gray t-shirt this time. The shirt was huge on her, hanging off one shoulder, the hem barely covering her hips.

Roman's fingers were in her hair, combing through it slowly. They were talking quietly, her looking up at him, both of them relaxed and easy.

I stood in the doorway watching them. Jess stretched, arching her back, and the t-shirt rode up, showing more of her thighs, the curve of her hip, the sides of her breasts bare beneath.

She turned her head and saw me, and her face lit up.

"Morning!" she said.

She sat up and the t-shirt fell back into place, covering her. She stood and walked to me, barefoot, her legs long and bare beneath the shirt.

She pressed herself against me, her whole body fitting into mine, and kissed me. Her mouth was soft and hot and tasted like coffee. When she pulled back she smiled.

"I'll make more coffee for you too," she said.

She slipped past me into the cabin. Roman was still on the daybed, one arm stretched along the back, watching the river. I went out and sat in one of the chairs.

"Sleep okay?" he asked.

"Yeah. You?"

He took a long time to answer, so long I wondered if her heard my return question. Finally, he said, “Once it was quieter.”

Jess came back with mugs for both of us just then and settled onto the daybed, this time sitting with her legs crossed, the t-shirt riding up dangerously high. She didn't seem to notice or care.

We drank coffee and talked about the day. Jess wanted to take the canoe out again, maybe explore further upstream. Roman suggested another hike. I said I'd be happy with either.

Jess stretched again, arms overhead, the shirt pulling tight across her chest. Roman's eyes followed the movement and she caught him looking. She grinned at him and leaned over to poke his side.

"Stop staring at my tits," she said.

"I'm not."

"Liar." she stretched again, dipping sideways now teasing him with it.

She poked him again too, and he grabbed her wrist. They wrestled playfully for a moment before she pulled free, laughing. She got up and announced she was going to shower.

Roman and I sat on the porch in silence, drinking our coffee, listening to the water run inside the cabin. When Jess came out she was dressed in shorts and a bikini top, her hair wet and pushed back.

"Let's make breakfast," she said, and we followed her inside.

Rain suddenly burst out of the sky. Through the windows the rain fell in sheets, obscuring the trees.

"It's really coming down," she said.

Roman came down from the loft in sweatpants and a t-shirt. The three of us stood in the kitchen drinking coffee, watching the rain.

"Well, I guess we're not hiking today," Jess said.

"Cards?" Roman suggested.

"Perfect."

We made breakfast together, all of us moving around the small kitchen. Jess stayed in the t-shirt and panties, completely unselfconscious, reaching across Roman for the bread, bending to get a pan from the low cabinet. The shirt rode up when she stretched, showing the white fabric of her panties, the curve of her ass.

After breakfast we cleared the table and Roman got a deck of cards. We played rummy at first, then switched to poker with matchsticks for chips. Jess sat between us and we drank beer even though it was barely noon.

The rain kept falling and the cabin felt smaller, the three of us enclosed in the gray light and the sound of water hitting the roof.

Roman's hand appeared on Jess's bare thigh under the table. I saw it when I leaned back to stretch, his palm resting on her skin just above her knee. As I watched, his hand slid higher, fingers squeezing into the soft flesh of her inner thigh.

Jess shifted in her seat, her legs parting. She dealt cards badly, dropping one, forgetting whose turn it was. Her teeth caught her bottom lip and she breathed differently, shorter.

I shifted in my chair as though stretching for my legs to prop up on the side table, giving me a view, if I was careful, over the edge of the table and over Jess's lap.

His hand kept moving higher on her thighs. Her hips shifted forward in the chair. She leaned into his side, her shoulder against his arm.

"Your turn," I said.

"What?" She looked at her cards like she'd forgotten she was holding them. "Oh. Right."

She played a card, the wrong one, and Roman collected the trick. His hand stayed on her upper thigh, thumb moving in small circles.

By late afternoon we'd switched to drinking whiskey. She was sitting in Roman's lap now, sideways, her legs draped over his thigh. Her arms were around his neck and she played with his hair while we continued the game, just Roman and I.

She leaned in and kissed his cheek, then his jaw. Her lips moved to his ear and she whispered something I couldn't hear. He smiled and his free hand tightened on her waist.

"Are we still playing or what?" I asked.

"Yeah, yeah," Jess said. She kissed Roman's ear again, teeth grazing, then looked at her cards. "I'm out though, obviously." She chuckled lightly and licked her broad tongue up Roman's cheek. He ignored it, and she snickered some more.

She tossed her cards down and settled more fully against Roman's chest. His hand slid up under the t-shirt, resting on her bare back.

The game fell apart after that. Jess pushed Roman to the couch, made him sit on it, laid down with her legs over his lap. "A perfect day for doing nothing but reading," she said. She pushed a random book into Roman's hands and laughed.

She stretched deeper along the couch with her legs further across Roman's lap and she pulled a blanket over both of them. I picked up a book

and pretended to read, too. Jess didn't even pretend to read, didn't get a book. Roman grinned after opening the book she gave him to some random page in the middle.

Under the blanket I could see movement, Roman's arm shifting, his hand working beneath the fabric. Jess's breathing changed and deepened. Her hand came out from under the blanket and gripped his arm, fingers tight.

A small sound escaped her, barely more than a breath. Then another. Her hips shifted under the blanket and she bit her lip and glanced at me as though checking if I noticed. I pretended to be deeply engaged with my book.

Roman's hand kept moving. She made a soft whimpering sound. She turned toward him, her free hand coming up to his face, and she stretched and then kissed him. This time it was not playful or teasing but deep and hungry, her mouth open against his. She didn't look at me. It was as though she was resigning herself to some reality. It was as though she couldn't afford to check on me anymore.

His hand under the blanket moved faster and she broke the kiss, gasping. Her body moved against his, a slow grinding rhythm. She kissed him again, desperate, and he pulled her closer.

I turned a page in my book. The words flowed meaningless. The cabin was dark in the daytime, the clouds thicker, the sky darker. The rain was loud on the roof, obscuring her gaps and her breath.

I stared harder at my book my face right down in the pages, unsure what was going on, disbelieving that it was happening in front of me. I didn't know what to say, my heart was beating too hard, my throat was dry. I new Jess was feeling very different that week, that was clear enough at night in bed with me.

They were just friends, she said. I kept telling myself that. I didn't want to be the one to draw tension to what was going on. I kept pretending that it was just two old friends being affectionate.

But Jess's breathing got faster, more ragged. Small sounds kept escaping her, breathy and high. She buried her face against Roman's neck and her whole body went tense.

"Jesus, Roman," she whispered close into his ear.

I swallowed hard, even shut my eyes in case I accidentally saw something. I thought about leaving the room, but even that would draw

attention.

Her body shuddered and she clung to him. When she finally relaxed she remained pressed against him, still breathing hard.

Several minutes passed in silence. Then Jess pushed the blanket off and stood abruptly. Her t-shirt was twisted and her face was flushed, her lips thick.

"I think I need air," she said.

She went to the back door and stepped out onto the covered porch. Roman waited maybe ten seconds before following her, grinning, but not making eye contact with me. It was like he was trying to escape the room.

I remained in my chair, the book open in my hands. Through the window I could see them on the porch. Jess was against the railing and Roman moved to her, his hands going around her waist.

They kissed immediately, hard and urgent. His hands slid up under her t-shirt and she arched back into him. One of her legs hitched up around his hip and he pressed against her, grinding her. His hands were everywhere, pushing the shirt up to expose her breasts, cupping them, his mouth moving to her neck.

She threw her head back and he kissed down her throat. She didn't seem concerned anymore to keep herself covered, or maybe she just couldn't anymore. Her hands were in his hair, pulling him closer. She wrapped both legs around him and he lifted her, supporting her weight against the railing.

They stayed like that for long minutes, moving against each other, hands roaming, hips grinding.. Finally they separated and stood close together, foreheads touching, both breathing hard, murmuring to each other. Jess pulled at her panties and gaped at him.

They came back inside separately, Jess first, her hair messed and the t-shirt twisted around her body. She went straight to the bedroom without looking at me. "Just need to lie down I think, maybe not feeling well," she explained.

Roman sat down on the couch, running his hands through his hair. Neither of us said anything.

I heard the shower go on in the bathroom. Roman picked up the remote and started scrolling through his downloaded movies like nothing happened.

When Jess came out she was in different clothes, leggings and a sweatshirt. She hesitated in the middle of the room like she was unsure

where to go, unsure what to do. She looked like she was fighting something. Then with resignation registering throughout her body, she came to the couch and curled up next to Roman and he put his arm around her automatically.

"So what are we pretending to watch this time?" she asked. Her hand pushed under his t-shirt and roamed around his chest.

I made some dinner while they picked a movie. We ate on the couch, plates balanced on laps, the movie playing on his laptop, some action thing with explosions and car chases.

Jess kept glancing at me, her eyes bright and guilty at the same time. I pretended not to notice.

After dinner she came to me in the kitchen while Roman was in the bathroom. She pressed against my back, her arms around my waist.

"I'm sorry," she whispered.

"What about?" I asked. I was not prepared for the conversation yet.

She kissed my shoulder blade through my shirt. "It's been a weird day. Being stuck inside. I'm really not feeling myself. You understand, don't you?"

"Yeah."

"So what, right?" she said. "I guess we just do that each other."

"I guess," I said.

"Do you want me to stop?"

I took a long time to answer. I turned around in her embrace and we stared into each other's eyes. I had so many words, they all bunched up together like too many people trying to get out the same narrow door.

She held me for another moment, then let go and went back to the couch.

We watched the rest of the movie. When it ended I announced I was going to bed early, I was too tired for more.

"Goodnight," she said to me with grinning pout. I half expected her to follow me, but was not surprised she didn't right away.

I was out like a light, fast asleep. I don't know how long it was, but I work up in a state of uncertainty about where I was.

Then from above, through the ceiling, I heard a different kind of sound. I head movement in the loft, the wooden floor creaking.

I went still, listening, held my breath.

The creaking developed a rhythm, slow at first, then faster. It was steady and unmistakable.

Then I heard her voice, faint but clear enough. There was a gasp, then words I couldn't make out. The creaking continued and she made another sound, louder this time.

"Roman," she said. Not loud but audible through the ceiling. "Oh god, Roman."

My heart hammered in my chest. I stared at the ceiling, every muscle in me tense.

The rhythm continued, the ceiling creaking faster. Her voice came in gasps and moans now, punctuated by murmured jolted words unclear and muffled, like a hand was over her mouth, hers or his?

It went on for what seemed like forever, five minutes, maybe more. Her sounds were getting louder, more desperate. The ceiling creaked faster and harder.

Then came a sharp cry and the rhythm faltered. Her voice cried unmistakable but loud enough that she had to know I could hear.

There was silence for a moment, then light hushed laughter, and then it started again.

I lay frozen, my hands in fists at my sides. The creaking resumed, faster than before. Her voice came almost immediately, moaning, the sounds she made raw and unrestrained.

I squeezed my eyes shut but couldn't block it out. I couldn't stop hearing her, couldn't stop imagining what was happening directly above me.

It built and built, her voice rising, the impacts getting faster. Then she cried out, long and broken, and the rhythm stuttered and stopped.

I lay in the dark, my heart pounding so hard I could hear it. Minutes passed. The rain fell. I didn't move a muscle.

Eventually I heard movement above and quiet voices, too low to make out words, and then silence again.

When gray light filtered through the window I heard sounds from the loft. There was movement and rustling followed by her laugh, bright and clear for just a moment.

I remained in bed, eyes closed, listening to them move around above me. The ladder creaked as someone climbed down. There were footsteps across the floor and the sound of the bathroom door closing.

Then the bedroom door opened quietly and Jess slipped in. She lifted the covers and slid into bed beside me, her body hot and smooth against mine.

She kissed me, deep and slow. Her mouth tasted different. Her skin smelled like sex and sweat..

She pulled back and looked at me, her eyes searching my face.

"Wakey, wakey. Did you sleep well?" she asked softly. "I stayed in bed for you this morning so you didn't have to wake up alone."

"Yeah, slept okay," I lied.

She kissed me again, her hand on my face. Then she sat up and stretched, her back arching. She got out of bed and went to her bag, pulling out fresh panties. "I slept very well."

She held up the shirt she was wearing, showing me the front by stretching it down. It was Roman's, black with a faded band logo.

"Look," she said. "It's The National. You used to love them."

It hung huge on her, the hem reaching her thighs.

"I'm just borrowing it," she said, grinning. "Roman said I could."

She disappeared into the bathroom and I heard the shower go on.

I got out of bed and pulled on shorts and a t-shirt. When I came out of the bedroom Jess and Roman were in the kitchen together like they were every morning, and it made me stop and wonder this time.

She was in just his black t-shirt and panties again. He had his hand on her waist, holding her close.

She picked up a piece of strawberry and held it to his mouth. He took it, his lips closing around her fingers. When he pulled back she offered him another and this time he caught her wrist, holding her hand in place.

He took the fruit and her fingers into his mouth, his tongue sliding between them. She watched his face, her lips parted, her breath coming faster.

When he released her hand she laughed and squirmed against him.

"That's cheating."

"How is it cheating?"

"You know how."

The conversation was quiet and intimate.

She turned back to what she was making, pressing her ass back against him briefly before moving away with a snicker. He watched her move around the kitchen, his eyes following her.

I sat at the table and poured myself coffee from the pot they'd already made.

Jess brought plates to the table, pancakes and fruit. She sat down next to Roman, across from me, and pulled one leg up under her. The t-shirt had ridden high on her thighs.

"Sleep okay?" Roman asked me.

"Yeah. You?"

"Great."

Jess glanced at him and grinned, then looked down at her plate to hide it. A faint flush colored her cheeks.

We ate breakfast while the rain continued outside, softer now but steady. Jess talked about what we should do today, whether the rain would stop, if we should just stay in and relax.

Her hand kept finding Roman's under the table. Their fingers tangled together and she squeezed, holding on.

When the rain seemed to stop, we decided on a small hike. She went inside and came back out with shorts pulled on over her panties but still wearing Roman's shirt. We headed out.

On the trail Jess walked beside Roman, their hands linked openly. I followed a few paces behind, watching them move together, her leaning into his shoulder, both of them talking and laughing.

Where the trail narrowed between two large trees, they stopped. Roman pressed her back against one of the trunks and kissed her, his hands sliding under the shirt and up her bare back. She arched into him and his hands moved lower, gripping her ass inside her shorts, pulling her against him.

Did they forget I was with them? I stopped about 20 feet back. I was paralyzed again, my throat constricted, my mind swirling, my words bunched up together.

His hand came around to her front, sliding up under the shirt to cup her breast. She gasped against his mouth, her head falling back against the tree. He kissed down her neck while his hand worked under the fabric, squeezing her, his thumb moving over her nipples.

She was panting now, her hips jutting against him. "Roman," she breathed.

I cleared my throat and kept walking. They separated as I approached, Jess's face flushed, her breathing uneven. They fell in behind me and we continued hiking.

We made a loop and came back to the cabin an hour later. Inside, Jess pulled off the shorts and went to the couch in just the t-shirt and panties.

Roman sat beside her and she immediately climbed into his lap, facing him, her legs wrapping around his waist. His hands went to her hips and she leaned in, kissing him deeply.

I went to the kitchen and started washing the breakfast dishes. I could see them on the couch behind my back. She was grinding against him, the movement slow and deliberate. His hands slid up under the shirt, moving over her bare back, down to grip her ass, up over her breasts. There was no pretense left, there was no attempt to hide anything.

Had I said yes to her? Had I inadvertently agreed to it?

She broke the kiss to gasp, her head falling back. He kissed down her throat while she kept moving her hips on him, the rhythm steady and unmistakable.

I dried the dishes slowly. They didn't stop. She pulled the t-shirt over her head and dropped it on the floor behind her and unclasped her bra, shook her arms to let the slack straps fall down to her hands, and she draped it over the back of the couch, her breasts now free and bare. He leaned forward and took one nipple in his mouth and she cried out, her hands in his hair.

I walked through the room to get something from the bedroom. They didn't even pause, didn't acknowledge me. She was topless in his lap, grinding hard against him, both of them breathing heavily.

In the bedroom I sat on the edge of the bed and stared at the door. I could hear them out there, her moans and his low voice saying things I couldn't make out. I shut the door and leaned against the window staring at the surrounding forest. I shut my eyes hard when I heard her gasp out loud, when I heard her cry with a sharp sudden yelp, when I heard the rustle of bodies slapping on the couch.

Eventually it went quiet. When it remained quiet long enough, I came out and found them still on the couch, her curled against his chest now, the t-shirt back on, but not her panties.

The day passed slowly. They touched constantly, casually, like they'd been together for years, her hand on his arm, his fingers in her hair, her body pressed against his whenever they stood close.

I made dinner and we ate mostly in silence. Jess sat next to Roman, their legs touching, her hand on his thigh under the table.

After dinner we went to the fire pit. The wood was damp but caught eventually. Jess didn't sit in her own chair. She climbed into Roman's lap immediately, straddling him, facing him.

She kissed him while I arranged the firewood. When I sat down she was moving against him again, a slow grinding rhythm. His hands were on her hips, guiding her movement.

She threw her head back and moaned, loud enough to echo across the clearing. Her hips moved faster and his hands gripped her harder. She was riding him with top and skirt on, but the motion was unmistakable and explicit.

I fed the fire and watched the flames. Behind me I could hear her breath getting faster, hear the small cries she made.

Her rhythm faltered and she shuddered, clinging to him. They stayed frozen for a moment, then she collapsed forward onto his chest.

After a while she stood up, her legs unsteady. She held out her hand to Roman and he took it. She led him toward the cabin.

Inside, she led him to the ladder and started climbing, still in just the t-shirt and no panties.

I went to the bedroom and closed the door again. I lay on the bed fully clothed, staring at the ceiling.

It didn't take long before the sounds started all over, the ceiling creaking, her voice, and his. There was no attempt at being quiet. She was loud immediately, crying out, saying his name.

The rhythm was fast and hard, the loft ceiling creaking like an old ship in high waves. She screamed his name and the sound of it filled the cabin, filled my head.

It went on and on. Every time I thought it was over it would start again. Different positions, different rhythms, but always her voice, always his name.

I lay there and listened to all of it.

Sometime late at night it finally went quiet. I dozed off and woke to morning light .

It was our last day. We needed to pack and clean the cabin before leaving.

I got up and started gathering my things. Through the open bedroom door I could see Jess climbing down the ladder in just panties, her breasts bare. She saw me and waved, unconcerned for anything more than a shrug.

She found Roman's t-shirt on the floor by the couch and came to the bedroom.

"Morning," she said brightly. She kissed me quickly. "I'll help pack."

She moved around the room collecting her things, folding clothes, chattering about the drive home. It was like nothing had changed, like everything was normal.

Roman came down from the loft and started packing his stuff. We all worked together, cleaning the kitchen, stripping beds, sweeping floors.

Jess stayed in the t-shirt and panties all morning, walking between the bedroom and the main room.

By afternoon the cabin was clean and our bags were packed by the door.

The cabin had to be cleared by noon. Jess went to change and came out of the bedroom in a short yellow sundress, the same one from earlier in the week. It hung loose from thin straps.

She bent to pick up a bag by the door and I saw she wasn't wearing a bra.

We loaded the car in silence, carrying bags and coolers out to the trunk. Roman brought his duffel down from the loft. Jess moved between us, helping, the dress swirling around her thighs.

I did a final walkthrough of the cabin, checking that we hadn't left anything. The bedroom looked empty and impersonal again, like we'd never been there. The loft was neat, the bed made.

I locked the door and put the key back in the lockbox. We stood on the porch for a moment looking out at the trees and the river beyond.

"Ready?" I asked.

Jess nodded. We got in the car, me in the driver's seat. Roman climbed in the back.

I started the engine and Jess looked over her shoulder at the back seat.

"Actually, is it okay if I stretch out back there?" she asked. "I didn't sleep very well last night."

"Sure," I said, thinking her and Roman would switch.

She climbed between the seats, her dress flying up, and settled into the back next to Roman. When I realized she meant to ride in the back with him, I pulled out of the clearing and onto the rough track through the trees and onward to home.

In the rearview mirror I watched them arrange themselves. Roman lay back against the door and Jess curled against him, her head on his chest. He

pulled her closer and her leg draped over his. They sank down together further and further.

We reached the main road and I turned toward the highway. The drive home would take about an hour and a half.

Within minutes they were shifting in the back seat more. I glanced in the mirror, adjusted it down, and saw them kissing, her mouth on his, deep and hungry. His hand slid up her thigh, pushing her dress higher.

She made a quiet sound, almost a laugh, breathless and pleased. The kissing continued and I heard the rustle of fabric and movement.

I turned on the radio, found a station, put the volume up.

In the mirror her dress had ridden up completely, bunched around her waist. She was lying on top of him now, her body moving. Though I could only see parts of entwined bodies, the rhythm was unmistakable.

Her gasps came in short bursts, punctuated by whispered words I couldn't quite hear. The car rocked with their movement.

I kept my eyes on the road, hands tight on the wheel. The highway stretched ahead, straight and empty.

The sounds continued, her breathing getting faster, sharper, his low voice murmuring things. I heard the creak of the seat, the rustle of clothing, the wet sounds of their bodies moving together.

I turned the radio up another notch.

It went on for miles. Every time I thought they'd finished, the sounds would start again with a different rhythm, a different position, her crying out, muffled, him groaning, both of them lost in it.

A gas station appeared ahead and I pulled off, grateful for the excuse. I parked at the pump and shut off the engine.

The sudden silence was deafening.

I got out and they emerged from the back seat a moment later. Jess's dress was completely twisted, one strap falling off her shoulder. Her hair was wild, tangles everywhere. Her face was flushed deep pink and her lips were thick and dark.

When she stepped out I saw her panties on the floor of the back seat where they'd been discarded.

She came around the car and kissed my cheek while I held the gas pump.

"Thanks for driving," she said softly. "And thanks for being so understanding."

Her pupils were huge and she smelled like sex. She went inside to use the bathroom and Roman went to the other one. I filled the tank and waited.

When they came back Jess looked more composed, her dress straightened, though her hair was still half a mess. They climbed back into the rear seat and I got behind the wheel.

I pulled back onto the highway. The city appeared on the horizon, buildings rising against the sky. Traffic picked up and I had to focus on merging, changing lanes.

Behind me there were no more sounds, no more movements. I glanced in the mirror and saw Jess asleep against Roman's chest. His hand was inside the top of her dress, cupping her breast, holding her as she slept, him sleeping now too.

I found our street and pulled into a spot near the building. I cut the engine and sat for a moment in the silence.

"We're here," I said quietly.

Roman shifted and Jess stirred, blinking awake. She sat up slowly and looked around, confused for a moment. Then she smiled and reached down to pull her dress into place.

Roman's hand slid out from inside her dress and he stretched.

We got out and opened the trunk. I started pulling bags out and setting them on the sidewalk. Jess grabbed her duffel and Roman took his.

He set his bag down and turned to Jess. He pulled her close and kissed her, deep and slow, his hands sliding down to grip her ass through her thin dress. The kiss went on for long seconds, both of them holding each other tight.

When they finally separated she was breathless, smiling up at him.

"See you soon?" she asked.

"Definitely."

He grabbed his bag and waved to me. "Great week, man. Thanks for letting me crash." He tried to clasp my hand but I didn't give him the pleasure.

"Yeah," I said. "That was good."

He walked away down the sidewalk and Jess watched him go. Then she turned to me and took my hand, lacing her fingers through mine.

"Come on," she said, leaning into my side. "Let's get inside."

We walked toward the building entrance, her hip bumping mine, her head resting briefly on my shoulder.

"Did you have fun?" she asked. She mussed my hair and chuckled.

I looked at her. Her eyes were bright and clear, her expression open and warm. It was like she genuinely wanted to know.

"Yeah," I said. "I had a lot of fun." I was testing her, seeing how far it went like that with her.

She squeezed my hand and smiled. "Anyway, I doubt we'll see him again for another year or more."

I followed her in the door and up to our apartment, curious to see how long she could go without mentioning what happened.

We got to five minutes. We got past putting things in the laundry, got past having, finally, warm showers at home. We even got past making something to eat.

I had a lot prepared to say, of course. But it was like a delirium had overtaken me, the longer we went without acknowledging what went on up there. It was like long sleep deprivation when you can't sort what was real from what was some hallucination.

We passed the day doing our things and watched a show together, even. We got ready for bed together and still it was as though all was normal.

The only evidence at all that anything was different from before we left for the trip, was in how she came to me in bed. That was very different, and it remained the only sign to me that the whole week had even taken place.

She did everything to me, culminating in riding me to her own climax before nearly instantly passing out on the pillows beside me, curled up and warm.

It became a curiosity to me, to see how long before she would bring it up, before she thought to suggest we needed to talk. It went so long I began to forget it happened at all, began to doubt what I had myself witnessed.

The thing was, aside from what happened up there, our relationship in every way was better, the sex especially. I saw no reason to rush things either, eventually.

Of course it was over, of course I had to end it, of course she was out of my life. Once I was certain about that, it was then just choosing when. And I could keep that in my back pocket as long as I wanted, while in the meantime, I enjoyed a renewed girlfriend with a whole new persona in bed.